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Survey Experiments in Public Policy: A Systematic Literature Review

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ABSTRACT

This systematic literature review examines population-based survey experiments (PBSE) in public policy, analyzing 36 peer-reviewed articles from Web of Science and Scopus databases. Based on PBSE methodological literature and the review, four main types of PBSE are distinguished: methodological, direct (based on information provision), indirect (based on priming and framing), and factorial. The paper reviews the usage and main findings of PBSE in five policy domains: education, health, anti-crime, pension, and social policies. The main strengths, challenges, and "best practices" of PBSE relevant to policy scholars are summarized. The paper concludes with implications for future research.

摘要

本篇系统性文献综述研究了公共政策领域中基于人口的调查实验 (PBSE), 分析了来自Web of Science和Scopus数据库的36篇同行评审文章。基于PBSE方法论文献和综述, 区分了四种主要的PBSE类型:方法论型、直接型(基于信息提供)、间接型(基于启动和框架)和因子型。本文述评了PBSE在五个政策领域(教育、卫生、反犯罪、养老金和社会政策)的应用和主要发现。总结了PBSE对政策学者的主要优势、挑战和"最佳实践"。本文的结论提供了未来研究启示。

RESUMEN

Esta revisión sistemática de la literatura examina los experimentos de encuestas poblacionales (PBSE) en políticas públicas, analizando 36 artículos revisados por pares de las bases de datos Web of Science y Scopus. Con base en la literatura metodológica sobre PBSE y la revisión, se distinguen cuatro tipos principales de PBSE: metodológico, directo (basado en el suministro de información), indirecto (basado en la preparación y el encuadre) y factorial. El artículo revisa el uso y los principales hallazgos de los PBSE en cinco ámbitos de políticas: educación, salud, lucha contra la delincuencia, pensiones y políticas sociales. Se resumen las principales fortalezas, desafíos y buenas prácticas de los PBSE relevantes para los investigadores de políticas. El artículo concluye con implicaciones para futuras investigaciones.

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1 | Introduction

Experiments have become increasingly utilized methodologies across the social sciences, including public policy (John 2017). In general, experiments are conducted to determine whether responses in treatment and control groups are significantly different and caused by intervention. Experiments in public policy and related fields take three primary forms: field experiments (Hansen and Tummers 2020), laboratory experiments (Bozeman and Scott 1992), and population-based survey experiments (PBSEs) (Mutz 2011).

PBSEs have several important advantages compared to field and laboratory experiments. It includes more extensive and diverse samples exposed to experimental conditions and the ability to accommodate many experimental conditions (Mutz 2011). As a result, in addition to internal validity typical for all experiments, PBSE also has external validity. It is especially important for policy issues because policymakers have greater confidence in research done outside of the laboratory on representative samples of the target population rather than on a convenient sample of students, which is typical for many lab experiments (Mutz 2011). Consequently, PBSE "holds the potential to vastly increase the impact of social science research on public policy" (Mutz 2011, 52).

Not surprisingly, the popularity of PBSE has risen considerably during the last decade. It is visible even with a brief look into the main databases. When entering the keyword "population-based survey experiments" in the Web of Science and Scopus databases, the first records appear in 1997 and 1975. Only in 2018 did the number of published studies exceed 100 published articles. Since 2020, there has been a distinct increase, with 2022 dominating the number of articles in Scopus (205).

While several overviews on the methodology of survey experiments have been published (Haaland et al. 2023; Thomas 2024), they focus mostly on methodology rather than substance. More importantly, they deal with PBSE in economics and politics, and there is no systematic review of PBSE in public policy. Compared to its use in other areas, PBSE's are underutilized in public policy. It is surprising, especially when considering PBSE's potential usefulness and that survey experiments originated with a clear policy focus (Sniderman and Druckman 2011). The aim of this article is thus to fill this gap and provide a systematic review of PBSE directly addressing public policy scholars. In so doing, we focus on substantive rather than methodological aspects of PBSE.

This article is structured as follows. First, we define PBSE and provide its working typology. Then, we describe the methodology of the review, followed by a summary of the main findings. In the discussion section, we return to the four main questions. We conclude with recommendations and possible directions for future research.

2 | Population-Based Survey Experiments

PBSE refers to special kinds of experiments aiming at combining the high external validity of representative surveys with the high internal validity of experiments. Another common term for it is "survey experiment." It is, however, partly confusing because survey techniques can also be used in field and laboratory experiments. What distinguishes PBSE from other research designs is not the survey technique or location but the combination of representative sample and randomized assignment. In other words, PBSE combines random sampling with random assignment (Lavrakas et al. 2019). The sample need not be nationally representative, but the requirement is that convenience samples are abandoned in favor of samples representing the target population of interest (Mutz 2011).

Theoretically, PBSE can be done in just one location (as in a laboratory experiment) and using techniques different from those of a survey. In practice, however, it only includes survey experiments where treatment is executed remotely. Consequently, the term "survey experiments" is often synonymous with PBSE. Nevertheless, "survey experiments" are sometimes labeled surveys using convenient samples (Nock and Guterbock 2010). In this sense, PBSE is viewed as a subtype of survey experiments. Although even convenient samples might be, under some conditions, partially generalizable (Mullinix et al. 2015), compared to PBSE, they have much lesser utility and cogency because of their questionable external validity.

To complicate things even further, sometimes the PBSE is discussed under "information provision experiment" (IPE) (Haaland et al. 2023). It is not surprising because information provision is central to PBSE. As one of the founding fathers of PBSE, Paul Sniderman, noted, survey experiments can be understood "... not as an intervention or manipulation, but as a variation in the information presented or highlighted for respondents." (Sniderman 2018, 260). Nevertheless, while survey experiments constitute a major part of IPE, field and laboratory experiments are also included under this category. On the other hand, PBSE is based on information provision in the form of "mere information" (see below).

PBSE can take multiple forms and designs. There is no commonly agreed typology of PBSE, and any classification scheme inevitably suffers from unclear boundaries. In this paper, we follow and adapt Mutz's typology to align with our review (Table 1). It serves as a tool to make readers sense of the diversity of possible utilization of PBSE and should not be taken rigidly. It is common to see studies that combine several purposes and may be classified under different types.

The first distinction is based on the main aim of PBSE. This can be either (1) methodological or (2) substantive (Nock and Guterbock 2010). First, survey experiments might be motivated to improve measurement. The direct predecessors of current PBSE are split-ballot designs in which researchers change either question-ordering or question-wording to see its effects on respondents (Gaines et al. 2007). More specific procedures, such as list treatments, were designed to measure respondents' positions on controversial or sensitive issues more properly.[1] Examples of this include a study by Daoust et al. (2021). They studied self-reported non-compliance with COVID-19 measures. To reduce the social desirability effect, they included a treatment "face-saving question" (strengthening that some people may also want to change their behavior but cannot do so for different reasons).

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TABLE 1 | Classification of PBSE.

Type	Purpose	Assumptions	Treatment technique
1. Methodological	Methodological—improve measurement		List technique and other approaches to reduce social desirability effects
2. Direct	Substantive—testing the effect of information provision	Learning mechanisms	Provision of neutral fact-based information
3. Indirect	Substantive—testing the effect of priming respondents to particular aspects	Priming, framing	Any treatment that induces respondents to alter their attention, mood, goal, priority (priming, framing)
4. Factorial	Substantive—testing the effect of concrete aspects of context	Context plays a role	Hypothetical (fictive) people, situations or policies in the form of different vignettes

Source: Authors, inspired by Mutz (2011).

Compared to the control group, self-reported non-compliance increased by 11% points.

The second main purpose of PBSE is to test substantive hypotheses. Here, the first distinction is made between "direct" and "indirect" treatments (Mutz 2011). Direct treatments are those in which the manipulation or intervention is clear to the participant or to anyone reading about the experiment's design (ibid. 37). It is easy for the respondent to see that he is being exposed to new information, a new argument, or some other intervention. The experimental treatment is pretty much what it appears to be. In indirect treatments, however, the relevant characteristics are not obvious to the respondent and often even to other researchers who do not realize the experiment. The goal is to indirectly induce an altered mood, goal, priority, or thought process of some kind (Mutz 2011).[2]

The difference between direct and indirect treatments is not always clear, and it is a matter of degree rather than a crossing line. However, the assumptions of direct and indirect treatments are different. Not surprisingly, different types of treatments are associated with different research traditions. Direct treatments are typically based on neutral, fact-based information provision. A prototypical example of direct treatments is using concrete problem quantifiers or reference points (anchoring). An implicit or explicit assumption behind this is that respondents do not have complete or correct information, and consequently, their reasoning is biased. It assumes that the cognitive process is deliberate and conscious and is influenced by the level of a "knowledge-deficit" approach. The interpretation of these PBSEs is then straightforward. It simply tests whether the provision of clear (and valid) information changes attitudes by filling in the cognitive gaps and leads to "genuine belief updating" (Haaland et al. 2023, 18).[3] In other words, it focuses on *learning* rather than *priming* (Fernández et al. 2023). It is very common in studies conducted by economists. For instance, Lergetporer et al. (2018) studied how support for increased education spending and teacher salaries change when respondents receive information about actual spending and salaries.

On the other side of the direct–indirect continuum are indirect treatments that aim not to "fill in the information gap" but to change how people think. The relevant characteristics are not clear to respondents. More importantly, treatments try to manipulate respondents' emotions or values, and respondents are induced or "incentivized" to different moods or reasoning. Examples include various types of priming. Priming refers to the activation of mental concepts through subtle situational cues. Typical priming techniques include prompting subjects to think about specific concepts or recollecting the past (Cohn and Maréchal 2016). This approach is popular, especially in political psychology. Examples of priming in public policy include the study of Heinzel and Liese (2021), who studied how the "mere mention" of an organization influences support for COVID-19 measures.

Last, there are factorial survey experiments (also called vignette or conjoint survey experiments). They lie somewhere between direct and indirect treatments and evolved as an independent category of survey experiments.[4] Vignettes refer to hypothetical (fictitious) situations in which objects, people, or the context of the study are systematically changed in some way. Respondents are provided with concrete and detailed descriptions of these selected characteristics that are systematically changed. The assumption behind factorial PBSE in public policy is that policy attitudes depend on specific aspects of the context. For instance, it is assumed that people do not form attitudes per se (e.g., toward pension policy) but are influenced by concrete dimensions. Prototypical examples include systematic variation of target groups in specific policies. For instance, in Lawrence et al. (2013) study, the respondents were randomly assigned a policy target (universal, the elderly, children, federal government workers, and single low-income mothers) to isolate the effect of target populations from other determinants of support.

3 | Review Methodology

This paper focuses on PBSE in public policy, covering educational, social, anti-crime, health, and pension policies. Substantive rather than methodological questions were considered. We are specifically interested in how this unique research design can be applied to policy questions. The aim of this review is (1) to systematically review the literature using IPEs in public policy, (2) to identify the main usages of IPSE in public policy, (3) to discuss the main weaknesses and strengths of the method in public policy, and (4) to identify possible future research opportunities for public policy.

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To provide comprehensive state-of-the-art survey experiments in public policy, we have conducted a systematic literature review (SLR), following the guidelines of the PRISMA framework (Liberati et al. 2009), to ensure the quality and transparency of the review process. Our review covers the period between 2010 and 2024. This paper employed the databases of Web of Science and Scopus to identify current sources of IPEs in public policy. Efforts were made to include the most relevant articles. The review, however, does not declare that the selected database is exhaustive.

Our search process followed three main steps. First, we searched the *Web of Science* (*WoS*) using the filter for *Author Keywords* and entered the term "survey experiment." At the same time, we searched *Scopus* using the filter for *Article Title, Abstract, and Keywords* with the keywords "survey experiment AND public policy." This initial search returned 1973 articles in WoS and 4193 articles in Scopus. To narrow down the WoS results, we focused on publication titles in journals closely related to public policy. In Scopus, we limited the subject area to human experiments in social sciences, psychology, neurosciences, decision sciences, nursery and multidisciplinary sciences.

This brought the total number of articles to *752 in WoS and 549 in Scopus*. Because the number of articles was still unmanageable for the review, we decided to reduce the review to just five policy sectors: anti-crime policy, education policy, health policy, pension policy, and social policy. While we acknowledge that this is a substantial reduction of the scope, we believe this is still an appropriate approach, given the paper's goal.

Next, we reviewed the *abstracts and conclusions* of these articles to assess their relevance to public policy. We excluded articles that were unrelated to public policy as well as duplicates and literature reviews. After this screening process, we identified *36 articles* for further review. The study includes 36 studies that reflect the emerging nature of PBSE in public policy and the stringent criteria used to maintain a clear focus. PBSE, while more established in other disciplines, remains a developing method in public policy, resulting in a smaller pool of relevant studies. The review prioritized studies that directly employed PBSE to address substantive public policy questions, ensuring methodological rigor and relevance. This approach emphasizes depth and specificity over breadth, offering a focused and meaningful synthesis of PBSE applications in public policy. Importantly, the limited number of studies also stems from a deliberate selection process, where we focused on specific journals and a few policy domains, explicitly excluding areas such as environmental, immigration, transport, economic, and trade policies. The dataset of all pre-selected journals and articles in WoS and Scopus, along with the selection criteria, is provided as Supporting Information S1.

4 | Results

Most of the reviewed articles originated from a specific national context. The distribution of studies is uneven, with the majority conducted in developed countries such as Germany, the USA, and Japan. This reflects the concentration of research resources and interest in these nations. The reviewed articles were published across various journals, highlighting the interdisciplinary nature of PBSEs in public policy research. Journals such as the European Journal of Political Economy, Social Science Research, and Comparative Political Studies featured prominently, indicating the growing recognition of PBSE's relevance in political and social science fields.

Based on our analysis of the scientific discourse in this area, the articles were systematically structured into five focus areas (in alphabetical order): anti-crime policy, education policy, health policy, pension policy, and social policy (Appendix A—Reviewed Articles). The frequency with which the various focus areas appear in the literature is shown in Table 2.

Table 3 provides a broad view of how public opinion influences policy preferences and willingness to support various initiatives. It presents key dependent variables related to public policy preferences, willingness to pay, and compliance intentions across several policy areas, such as crime prevention, education, and

TABLE 2 | Distribution of focus areas in reviewed articles.

Focus area	Number of articles
Anti-crime policy	3
Education policy	9
Health policy	11
Pension policy	3
Social policy	10
Total	36

Source: Authors.

TABLE 3 | Dependent variables.

Policy preferences and support	Anti-crime policy: allocation of resources to anti-crime policies, demand for punitive measures Education: support for increased education spending, and the introduction of tuition fees Health and social policies: compliance intentions for vaccine acceptance, support for poverty relief policies, and trust in social policy preferences. Support for abortion liberalization and for affirmative action Pension and social policy preferences: preferences regarding pension reform, redistribution, and specific social policy measures
Perceptions, attitudes and compliance intentions	Social and economic concerns: perceptions of the necessity for pension reforms Health policy: compliance intentions for vaccine acceptance Pension policy: pension contributions

Source: Authors.

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health. The table highlights people's willingness to support pension reform initiatives and comply with policies such as vaccine acceptance. Additionally, it captures public perceptions on energy use, immigration, and social policies, shaping their support for government interventions. The main usages of PBSE in public policy are identified below and clustered according to policy domains.

4.1 | Anti-Crime Policy

Studies by Gingerich and Scartascini (2022) and Cafferata et al. (2023) explore how different types of information influence public support for crime policies. Gingerich and Scartascini (2022) found that during high crime periods, support for punitive measures increases and tends to persist even when crime rates fall. High-crime messaging reinforces this preference, while low-crime messaging does not effectively shift public opinion toward social policies, indicating a strong tendency to favor punitive approaches.

In contrast, Cafferata et al. (2023) showed that providing information about the educational attainment of prisoners can shift public preferences toward social policies, highlighting the role of empathy, fairness, and perceived efficacy in driving support for more rehabilitative approaches. This suggests that while fear-based messaging tends to lock in support for harsher measures, information that humanizes offenders and emphasizes social interventions can promote more effective, compassionate policy alternatives. These findings imply that public attitudes toward crime policy are *highly responsive to the information presented*, with fear-based narratives bolstering punitive support and empathetic, rehabilitative messaging fostering support for social policies.

4.2 | Education Policy

In education policy, most studies use direct treatments. Of special interest to researchers is the effect of providing respondents with information on actual spending and attitudes on preferred-level educational spending. Lergetporer et al. (2018) and later Cattaneo et al. (2020) found for Germany, the US, and Switzerland that accurate information on spending and salaries *reduced* support for increases, as participants initially underestimated current funding levels. Treatment effects are substantially larger for respondents who underestimated actual funding levels and almost zero for already well-informed respondents. Thus, it indicates that this effect reflects the genuine effect of being better informed rather than primed. Information on spending levels also impacts tradeoffs among different policy measures. For instance, after being aware of costs, respondents shift their preferences from class-size reductions to either teacher salary increases or introducing new books and technologies.

This finding is particularly relevant for policy scholars as it suggests that *the mere provision of information can change attitudes* in policy domains where citizens have direct experience with a policy (such as education). It is possible to examine tradeoffs among educational policy measures (as Lergetporer did) and tradeoffs among educational levels. In this respect, Najam and Johnston (2022) found on data from Afghanistan that knowing the actual government spending level on primary/secondary and higher education significantly *decreases* support for greater financing of higher education relative to primary and secondary education. Similarly, it also led to more support for tuition in public universities.

Not all studies, however, have found the same effect in all aspects. This can be explained by the fact that respondents are only well-informed about some aspects of educational policy. In other words, the level of political sophistication, even within one policy domain, might differ. Anglum and Rhinesmith (2022) found that in Missouri, respondents favor increased school spending when providing information relating to local school spending to statewide averages. Nevertheless, they are insensitive to similar information on teachers' salaries. This is attributed to respondents being more knowledgeable about teacher salaries than school spending. They also found interactions with other factors, such as political ideology and perceptions of local school quality.

Another commonly used type of PBSE in education policy is a factorial design. It helps disentangle how policy support differs across target groups and specifications. The study of Steenwegen and Meijers (2024), for instance, reveals that public approval of minority-organized supplementary schooling varies to a significant degree by the ethnic community (i.e., Italian, Chinese, or Moroccan) and the school's stated purpose (i.e., heritage language training or math tutoring). The study shows that different combinations of treatment lead to different results. This insight has practical implications for educational policy because it draws policymakers' attention to the fact that no generally applicable policy can be implemented across all contexts.

4.3 | Health Policy

PBSE has demonstrated how communication strategies can significantly shape public health attitudes. These experiments demonstrate that the framing, presentation, and alignment of information with audience characteristics play a crucial role in influencing compliance and support for health initiatives. However, the degree of effectiveness varies, depending on the approach used and the context, emphasizing the need for a nuanced understanding of these interventions.

One of the most striking findings is the power of *loss-framed messages*, which focus on the negative consequences of non-compliance. These messages have consistently proven effective in encouraging vaccine acceptance. For instance, Wang et al. (2023) found that combining loss-framed messages with physician consultations led to a significant increase in vaccine uptake, outperforming financial incentives. Similarly, Goren et al. (2022) showed that negative financial incentives, such as higher taxes for non-compliance, were more effective than positive ones in promoting COVID-19 vaccination. These findings highlight how loss framing taps into emotional and cognitive responses, prompting individuals to act. However, the impact of these messages often depends on the audience's initial attitudes and perceptions of risk.

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Beyond framing, *narrative messaging* has emerged as a compelling approach to enhancing compliance. Narratives make risks more relatable and personal, fostering a deeper emotional connection with the message. Ye et al. (2021) demonstrated that narrative-based approaches significantly improved vaccination intentions compared to non-narrative formats. Additionally, Ylisalo et al. (2023) emphasized that vaccination policies are more effective when their justifications align with herd immunity thresholds. While these strategies yield meaningful results, questions remain about their long-term effectiveness, suggesting the need for ongoing communication to reinforce attitudinal changes.

The influence of *demographics and broader societal contexts* also shapes the effectiveness of PBSE interventions. For example, traditional messaging strategies addressing obesity prevention fail to drive meaningful attitudinal change, as noted by Reynolds et al. (2020). This underscores the need for innovative approaches that resonate more effectively with the target audience. Additionally, Heinisch and Werner (2024) highlighted how concerns about personal freedoms, trust in government, and transparency can impact the success of health messaging during crises. These societal attitudes can amplify or diminish the effectiveness of interventions, requiring communicators to address underlying trust and transparency issues.

These findings underscore framing and personalization's importance in public health messaging. Loss framing and narrative strategies effectively engage the public by leveraging cognitive and emotional triggers. At the same time, context-specific justifications can enhance the acceptance of controversial policies, such as vaccination mandates.

4.4 | Pension Policy

The studies consistently highlight the critical role of effectively communicating relevant information to shape public attitudes and build support for pension reforms. These experiments reveal that both the content of the information and the way it is presented significantly influence public attitudes toward policy changes.

One of the key findings emphasizes *the salience of demographic change* as a driver of public support for pension reforms. Schuetz et al. (2023) demonstrated that highlighting demographic trends—such as the increasing ratio of retirees to working-age individuals—substantially increases support for reform measures. Their findings suggest that the prominence of this information is as important as its accuracy, as it helps the public grasp the urgency of reform.

Additionally, *neutral and factual communication* is a powerful tool for fostering support for sustainable reforms. Fernández et al. (2023) found that providing clear, non-partisan information about projected declines in future pension benefits builds public backing for financially responsible changes, such as raising retirement ages or reallocating funds. Such communication minimizes biases and encourages informed decision-making by avoiding politically charged narratives.

However, these findings also highlight the persistent challenge of *societal biases* in shaping public attitudes toward pensions. Naumann et al. (2024) revealed evidence of welfare chauvinism in Germany, where Turkish pensioners are perceived as less deserving than their native counterparts, even when their contribution histories are identical. This suggests that cultural prejudices can undermine the equitable implementation of reforms, even when the policies are designed to be fair.

These studies underscore the importance of clear communication and addressing underlying societal biases in pension policy. While well-crafted, salient, and neutral information can significantly enhance public understanding and support for reforms, these efforts may be insufficient if cultural and social prejudices remain unaddressed.

4.5 | Social Policy

The studies have demonstrated the powerful influence of information, narratives, and framing in shaping public opinion. These findings reveal that emotional engagement, social constructions, and cost awareness are critical in determining public support for controversial and welfare-related policies.

One of the most effective strategies for garnering support is through *narrative storytelling*. Kawata et al. (2023) found that stories highlighting individual struggles evoke strong emotional responses, making them more impactful than statistical evidence in generating support for poverty relief. This aligns with Slater and Rouner's (1996) assertion that narratives are uniquely effective in challenging deeply held beliefs. Similarly, Kawata and Nakabayashi (2023) observed that even simple information exchanges can shift preferences for income redistribution, while Colombo and Ray (2024) showed that positive information enhances social trust and increases support for generous social policies. These findings underscore the importance of humanizing policy discussions to foster empathy and trust.

The role of *framing* further emphasizes the impact of how policies are presented. Bell (2021) demonstrated that public opinion on affirmative action is shaped by the social construction of target populations, a finding echoed by Lawrence et al. (2013), who advocate for designing policies that account for these constructions to gain broader public support. However, framing policies around costs can have a dampening effect on public support. For instance, Zakharov (2024) found that raising awareness of actual social security costs reduced support for government spending, highlighting the sensitivity of public opinion to financial considerations.

Ethnically targeted welfare policies face particular challenges in diverse societies. Ford and Kootstra (2017) noted significant opposition to welfare policies targeted at specific ethnic groups. Meanwhile, Zhirkov et al. (2023) found that how welfare opinions are measured influences the perceived impact of racial stereotypes. Additionally, Thorp and Larner (2024) highlighted how framing is based on claimants' responsibility; for example, the perceived cause of a disability—strongly influences public

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support for welfare policies. These findings illustrate how biases and perceptions shape attitudes toward welfare programs.

Broader societal factors also complicate welfare state recalibration. Bremer and Bürgisser (2023) pointed out that citizens resist reallocating funds from pensions and education to other social policies, demonstrating a reluctance to make tradeoffs within the welfare system. Meanwhile, Chueri et al. (2024) challenged the assumption that Populist Radical Right Party (PRRP) voters are staunch supporters of a generous welfare state for "deserving" nationals, showing instead that they are generally less solidaristic.

Together, these studies highlight that public attitudes toward welfare and social policies are deeply influenced by how policies are framed, the narratives used, and the social constructions of target populations. While narratives and positive framing can foster support for welfare policies, raising awareness of costs and introducing ethnic targeting can diminish it.

5 | Discussion

The review has demonstrated that PBSE can benefit public policy scholars. The primary *strength* of PBSE lies in its combination of representative samples with the ability to make causal inferences rather than just observing correlations. This approach ensures that outcome differences are directly linked to experimental interventions, providing precise insights into how and why specific factors influence policy attitudes (Mutz 2011; Haaland et al. 2023).

This is what policymakers look for—an intervention that works outside research labs in real life. Many of the research findings reviewed in this article have clear policy implications (see Table 4). For instance, in education policy, factual information corrected misconceptions, leading to more informed and adjusted public preferences for spending. In health policy, loss-framed messages and narrative treatments effectively engaged cognitive and emotional responses, significantly enhancing outcomes such as vaccination acceptance. Similarly, emotional narratives fostered empathy in social policy and increased public support for poverty relief initiatives, demonstrating the power of tailored communication in shaping attitudes across diverse policy areas.

Reviewed studies consistently found that direct and indirect treatments might significantly influence public attitudes, albeit through different mechanisms. Direct treatments rely on providing factual and neutral information to correct misconceptions or align public perceptions with expert recommendations. In contrast, indirect treatments, such as narrative storytelling and priming, leverage mostly emotional engagement to drive change. While the effect of intervention depends on contextual factors, and it is not possible to generalize what types of treatments have more power in general, it might contribute to the current debate on "facts versus emotion" in public policy (Durnová 2019).

The review has shown that effect size might differ considerably across policy contexts and interventions. While we should be cautious about too much generalization, some findings are worthy of further investigation. Loss-framed messages are reported to generate robust and immediate changes in attitudes, particularly in health policy settings, where they significantly increase vaccination intentions (Wang et al. 2023; Ye et al. 2021). Narrative messaging also produced meaningful shifts, especially in welfare policies, where emotional engagement fostered sustained intervention support (Kawata et al. 2023). By comparison, interventions with lower salience or personal relevance, such as low-intensity messaging, had negligible effects. The type of messaging also plays a critical role in determining effectiveness. Narrative communication evoking emotional responses

TABLE 4 | Some policy implications of PBSE studies.

Stimulus type	Policy area	Implications
Cognitive stimuli (direct treatment)	Education policy	Providing information that aligns public perception with actual education spending can reduce support for increased spending and teacher salaries
	Pension policy	Information about demographic changes can influence preferences for pension reforms, such as increasing contributions or the retirement age
Indirect treatment (priming)	Anti-crime policy	Exposure to high crime information increases preferences for punitive policies, while low crime information does not significantly increase preferences for social policies
	Pension policy	Priming with demographic information about aging populations can increase the perceived necessity for pension reforms, such as raising the retirement age
Indirect treatment (emotional stimuli)	Social policy	Narrative information that evokes emotional responses is more effective in garnering support for poverty relief and education spending compared to statistical information
	Health policy	Loss-framed messages, emphasizing the negative consequences of non-compliance, are effective in promoting health-related behaviors such as vaccination

Source: Authors.

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seems to outperform statistical evidence in building support for social policies such as poverty relief (Kawata et al. 2023).

The review also documents another strength of PBSE: its versatility. It has been applied in multiple policy domains, including health, education, social policy, and pension reforms, showing its broad applicability and effectiveness in different sectors. PBSE can be tailored to different contexts, and by customizing the treatment to specific groups, PBSE ensures that the message resonates more deeply with the target audience. PBSE also allows various treatment formats, each having different impacts depending on the audience and issue. This flexibility in information presentation enhances the method's effectiveness in communicating complex policy issues to the public. In general, PBSE is a very universal tool for policy scholars seeking to address diverse issues.

Despite its advantages, PBSE faces several *challenges and limitations*. PBSE is not a panacea for all methodological issues like any other research technique. One of the most discussed issues is PBSE generalizability. It primarily relates to ensuring fully representative samples. In real research practice, researchers often rely on convenient samples instead due to the high costs associated with representative sampling. While some studies suggest that results may remain comparable (Mullinix et al. 2015), using non-representative samples undermines the core principles of PBSE. Moreover, PBSE is subject to more general challenges of survey research, including low response rates, reliance on quotas instead of fully probability-based samples, and other methodological issues. Most importantly, survey experiments depend critically on the degree of treatment effect heterogeneity (Coppock et al. 2018). It means that an intervention might not have the same effect on all individuals in a study. Instead, the size or direction of the effect can vary depending on characteristics like age, education, ideology, or other factors. Consequently, the use of quotas might significantly affect the overall results.

The second limitation concerns the possible "inflation parameter" (Gaines et al. 2007). This means that in an artificial, clean environment such as survey experiments and survey questions make treatment easier to receive than in real life, where people receive many competing treatments and might be distracted. Attempts have been made to compare the validity of the surveys and natural experiments (Barabas and Jerit 2010). Limited evidence suggests that the treatment effect's strength compared to real-life settings might be overestimated. Given the publication bias and tendency to publish positive findings on the treatment effects (Franco et al. 2014), this generally might lead to an overestimation of the treatment effect. Policymakers should be mindful of this distortion, and researchers should prioritize *replication across diverse contexts* to help ensure that conclusions are robust and not driven by selective reporting.

Long-term evaluation of treatment effects is another challenge. While short-term effects are well documented, their persistence over time remains unclear. Kawata and Nakabayashi (2023) found that narrative messaging could sustain its impact over time if reinforced, but the effects diminished without ongoing reinforcement. However, very little is known about the persistence of the intervention effect, and much more longitudinal research is needed.

The effectiveness of PBSE also varies across cultural and demographic contexts, making it difficult to generalize findings. This variability highlights the need for context-specific adaptations to ensure the method's effectiveness in different settings. For instance, the effectiveness of interventions may differ based on cultural norms, political climates, and group dynamics. The lack of cross-country comparisons in PBSEs represents a significant limitation and highlights an important avenue for future research. Addressing this gap could provide valuable insights into how policies are influenced by varying national contexts.

A notable limitation of the existing PBSE literature is also its heavy reliance on data from high-income societies. This geographic concentration raises concerns about the generalizability of findings, as social, economic, and institutional contexts in the global south may differ significantly. Acknowledging this imbalance, there is a clear need for more research in underrepresented regions, which could help test the external validity of current conclusions and inform more inclusive policy design.

The main strengths and weaknesses of PBSE in public policy are summarized in Table 5. It should be noted, however, that the challenges mentioned above are not unavoidable. In addition to standard procedures applicable to all kinds of surveys (Krosnick et al. 2015), the following specific "best practices" should be considered when designing PBSE. First, PBSE should be used on strong theoretical hypotheses, ideally with clear policy implications. Such hypotheses should be pre-registered to separate the hypothesis-generating phase from the hypothesis-testing phase. Preregistration would also ideally ease the later publishing of insignificant results.

Second, all studies should report on the effect size, that is, the strength of the treatment effect. As our review indicates, this is not always taken for granted. Many studies focus only on statistical significance, which is useless and complicates synthesis and theory building. Also, follow-up surveys should be used more frequently to detect the long-term impacts of initial interventions. For example, follow-up surveys can be used to track changes in public attitudes toward vaccination over several months or years in both treatment and intervention groups.

Another potential avenue for improving the robustness and generalizability of findings is the use of larger and more diverse samples. Broader samples help ensure that results are not limited to specific populations and increase the external validity of the conclusions. This consideration, however, naturally raises the question of optimal sample size. In the studies included in our review, sample sizes ranged widely from approximately 200 to over 15,000 respondents. While there is no universal benchmark, it is crucial to ensure that the sample size provides sufficient statistical power, particularly to detect null effects with reasonable precision. For instance, Haaland et al. (2023) suggest a minimum of 700 respondents per treatment arm to achieve this level of precision.

The issue of sample size becomes even more pertinent when using factorial survey experiments, especially those designed to detect interactions between respondent characteristics and vignette attributes. In such cases, D-efficient designs are increasingly favored, as they allocate vignettes in a way that maximizes the statistical efficiency of estimating interaction effects (Chueri

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TABLE 5 | Strengths and weaknesses of PBSEs in public policy.

Strengths		Weaknesses	
Influence on public preferences	PBSEs show how public attitudes and preferences can be influenced by providing factual, scientific information, aligning public opinion with expert consensus	Varying effectiveness across contexts	Effectiveness varies across settings, making it difficult to generalize findings
Versatility across policy domains	PBSEs have been applied across various public policy domains, showing their broad applicability	Sample size and external validity issues	PBSEs require large representative sample sizes and careful sampling methods to ensure external validity, so that the findings can be generalized to the broader population targeted by the public policy
Use of diverse information formats	PBSEs allow the use of various formats of information, each having different impacts depending on the audience and issue	Inflation parameter	The strength of treatment effect compared to real-life settings might be overestimated
Tailoring information for impact	PBSEs can be tailored to different demographics and contexts, enhancing its effectiveness		
Potential for encouraging sustainable choices	PBSEs can encourage socially desirable and sustainable choices, such as support for environmental conservation or vaccination		

Source: Authors.

et al. 2024). However, this strategy typically requires larger overall samples, since analyses often involve dividing respondents into subgroups (e.g., by gender, age, or education). As a result, rather than relying on generalized heuristics such as the 700-respondent rule, we recommend that researchers undertake formal power analyses to determine the appropriate sample size for their specific design and research objectives (Auspurg and Hinz 2014).

Last but not least, comparative PBSE is needed more. Only several studies reviewed (Lergetporer et al. 2018; Geven et al. 2021; Reynolds et al. 2020; Fernández et al. 2023) effectively tackled cross-country comparisons by employing parallel survey designs across multiple countries, allowing for a robust analysis of variations in public attitudes. These studies addressed contextual factors by incorporating country-specific variables such as differences in fiscal structures, cultural attitudes, policy salience, and baseline spending levels. Across the studies, the information's effects revealed shared patterns and variations unique to each context. By distinguishing between learning and priming, the studies demonstrated how prior knowledge, institutional frameworks, and the specifics of local policy debates influenced individual responses to information. Much more similar research is needed to uncover the general treatment effect from the cultural, economic, and political factors shaping each country's context.

6 | Conclusions

PBSEs have proved to be a valuable methodology for policy scholars. PBSE's ability to test the effects of different interventions and maintain high external validity makes it a powerful tool for evidence-based policymaking. Despite its growing popularity among social scientists, its use in public policy scholarship is underutilized. We hope this paper will encourage policy scholars to use the technique more frequently.

We acknowledge that PBSE is demanding in several ways, and researchers face several challenges, such as ensuring large representative samples or tailoring interventions to be, on hand, realistic and, on the other hand, potentially effective. While null effects are also potentially theoretically interesting, what policymakers look for are interventions that work, that is, that lead to some change.

Future research should expand in several ways. First, combining different interventions might provide a deeper understanding of how direct and indirect treatment might interact in shaping public attitudes. Second, long-term longitudinal studies should analyze the durability of the intervention. Last but not least, it is necessary to analyze how the measured effects translate to real behavior and to what extent they remain in the form of self-reported attitudes.

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Conflicts of Interest

The authors declare no conflicts of interest.

Endnotes

[1] Note that the distinction between methodological and substantive aims is blurred. For instance, even a simple question-wording experiment has substantive and methodological aspects, as methodologists draw on various theories to explain or manipulate observed outcomes (Nock and Guterbock 2010). Consequently, PBSE-specific designs can be classified differently. For instance, Mutz (2011) discusses list treatment under "improving measurement," while Nock and Gutterbock under "substantive" PBSE (2010).

[2] This distinction resembles the classification of Sniderman and Druckman (2011), who distinguished between manipulative, permissive, and facilitative designs. Indirect designs are arguably more manipulative than direct ones.

[3] Anchoring is also used to strengthen the comparability of self-reports and improve measurement.

[4] Mutz argues that it may be seen as a special type of *direct* population-based survey. On the other hand, she notes that "respondents are unaware that the focus is on certain characteristics of the people or policy they are judging" (64), and she discusses vignettes separately. We follow this and take vignettes as a distinct methodological approach.

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Appendix A

Reviewed Articles

Authors/year/journal/ participants	Country	Dependent variable	Treatment	Control group	Policy domain	Key findings	Type
Gingerich and Scartascini 2022 Journal of Public Policy $N = 1521$ General public	Panama	(1) The allocation of resources to different anti-crime policies (2) Policy preferences: Punishment vs. social policy Punishment vs. detection Detection vs. social policy	High crime information: showing a significant increase in homicide rates in Panama Low crime information: showing a significant decrease in homicide rates in Panama	$N = 507$ Did not receive any crime trend information	Anti-crime policy	Exposure to high-crime information increased support for punitive policies and decreased support for social policies, while low-crime information had little effect on social policy support and sometimes favored punitive measures. Informed citizens' preferences were less influenced than those of less informed citizens	2
Cafferata et al. 2023 Comparative Political Studies $N = 1625$ General public	Chile	Demand for punitive policies Operationalization: (1) allocation of fixed budget among sets of specific policies to reduce crime (2) Acceptance of unrestricted force by the police	Information on target population (extremely low levels of education of prisoners in Chile)	$N = 813$ Did not receive any information about the educational background of prisoners	Anti-crime policy	Respondents in the treatment group, who received information about prisoners' low educational attainment, showed significant changes in their policy preferences. With a fixed anti-crime policy budget, they allocated 20%–50% more toward socially oriented policies than the control group, demonstrating the influence of educational information on resource allocation decisions	2
Hickert et al. 2024 Journal of Experimental Criminology $n^1 = 1260$ (vaccination) $n^2 = 1256$ (taxes for PPE) General public	USA	Support for compassionate policies in prisons, vaccination and tax for personal protective equipment (PPE)	The spread of COVID-19 in prisons, highlighting prisoners' vulnerability	Not specified	Anti-crime policy	Public support for compassionate prison policies is generally lower compared to non-prisoner groups. Factors such as stigma, costs, and severity of health risks influence this support. Inclusionary moral values had limited effect	4
Clinton and Grissom 2015 Journal of Public Policy $N = 1500$ (Tennessee residents)	USA	Public opinion on education policy and institutional evaluations	Information on objective student performance and racial achievement gaps	Not specified	Education policy	Citizens updated their evaluations of institutions when given objective performance data, but information about racial achievement gaps did not significantly changed support for policy reforms	2
Lergetporer et al. 2018 Journal of Public Economics $n^1 = 4171$ (Germany) $n^2 = 2669$ (USA) General public	Germany USA	Support for increased education spending		$N = 146$ Did not receive any additional information about current spending levels or teacher salaries	Education policy	Information about current education spending and teacher salaries reduces support for further increases in both Germany and the U.S., particularly among those who previously underestimated these levels. In the U.S., the prospect of higher taxes and clearer trade-offs shifts preferences from reducing class sizes to increasing teacher salaries, while in Germany, it leads to a preference for purchasing new teaching materials	2
Bell 2021 Policy Studies Journal $N = 2850$ General U.S. adults	USA	Support for affirmative action	Different framing of affirmative action policies targeting different populations (race-based, high-achieving, income-based)	Not specified	Educational policy	Race-based affirmative action targeting saw significantly lower support compared to income-based targeting. The results suggest a complex relationship between social constructions of target populations and mass opinion	4
Wen and Witteveen 2021 Social Science Research $N = 1213$	USA	Attitudes toward family vs. government educational investment	Information on factual social mobility in the U.S. and Europe	$N = 300$	Education policy	The perception of high social mobility led to less support for government educational investment and more family financial responsibility	2

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Appendix (Continued)

Authors/year/journal/ participants	Country	Dependent variable	Treatment	Control group	Policy domain	Key findings	Type
Cattaneo et al. 2020 European Journal of Political Economy $N = 6262$ General (representative sample of adults aged 18–74)	Switzerland	Support for increased education spending Support for increased teacher salaries Preferences for allocation of additional education spending Support for class-size reductions	Providing information about actual spending levels, current salary levels, the relative costs of different spending options	$N = 1500–2000$ Did not receive any additional information about current spending levels or teacher salaries	Education policy	In the uninformed control group, 54% supported increased education spending. However, providing information about actual spending levels reduced this support by 14% points (a 26% drop relative to the control). Similarly, support for increasing teacher salaries, initially at 27% in the control group, fell by 8% after respondents were informed about current salary levels. Additionally, support for reducing class sizes declined, with preferences shifting toward spending on new books and technology	2
Anglum and Rhinesmith 2022 Social Science Quarterly $N = 950$ General public (registered voters from Missouri)	USA	Support for increased school spending Support for increased teacher salaries Preferences for types of taxation	Information about school spending and teacher salaries	$N = 475$ Had no information about school spending and teacher salaries	Education policy	Despite differences in spending preferences, the overall opinion still favored increased school funding and the associated tax hikes. A majority of voters supported maintaining or raising school funding and teacher salaries. Liberal and moderate voters, as well as those dissatisfied with local school quality, were more likely to back higher spending and salary increases. Tax preferences varied by political alignment, with liberals favoring income taxes and conservatives preferring sales taxes to fund these increases	2
Geven et al. 2021 Social Science Research $N = 177$ teachers (Amsterdam, Oslo, New York)	Netherlands, Norway, USA	Teacher expectations of student success (bachelor's degree completion)	Factorial survey with manipulated student traits (performance, SES, ethnicity, effort)	Not specified	Education policy	The study aimed to examine how elementary school teachers in Amsterdam, Oslo, and New York form educational expectations, focusing on the influence of student traits like performance, effort, SES, and ethnicity. Teachers prioritized these traits differently based on institutional contexts, with SES affecting expectations, especially when performance data was lacking	4
Najam and Johnston 2022 Education Economics $N = 777$ General public (the sample was not nationally representative but was instead more educated and urban)	Afghanistan	Support for the introduction of tuition fees Support for public spending on higher education	Information about the current amount of funding devoted to different levels of education	$N = 400$ Did not receive any additional information about public higher education financing	Education policy	On average, half of respondents opposed tuition in public HEIs, while over a third supported it. Information about nighttime student fees increased support for daytime fees by 16% points. Women were more likely to oppose tuition fees than men, and attitudes of graduates from private and public institutions were similar	2
Steenwegen and Meijers 2024 Journal of Ethnic and Migration Studies $N = 4689$ (Flemish citizens)	Belgium	Public support for minority-organized education spaces	Survey experiment on minority group (Italian, Chinese, Moroccan) and purpose of school (math tutoring vs. heritage language lessons)	Not specified	Education policy	Support for minority-organized schools varied by ethnic group and type of educational initiative. Italian-organized schools were most supported, while Moroccan-organized schools were least. Heritage language training generated less support than academic tutoring, especially for Moroccan communities	4

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Appendix (Continued)

Authors/year/journal/ participants	Country	Dependent variable	Treatment	Control group	Policy domain	Key findings	Type
Fox et al. 2022 Journal of Health Politics, Policy and Law $N=1211$	USA	Support for medicare for all (M4A)	Vignette priming about job and health insurance loss	$N=$ approx. 404	Health policy	Health insurance loss increased support for M4A by 10%–15% points; vignettes also increased support by 5.5% points	3/4
Daoust et al. 2021 Journal of Experimental Political Science $N=5963$	Canada	Self-reported compliance with COVID-19 public health measures	"Face-saving" strategies to reduce social desirability bias in self-reported compliance with COVID-19 measures such as guilt-free answer options	$N=2982$	Health policy	The face-saving treatments increased self-reported non-compliance by up to 11% points. Face-saving prompts, especially those with guilt-free answer choices, were most effective	1
Goren et al. 2022 Israel Journal of Health Policy Research $N=929$ General public	Israel	Compliance intentions Various vaccine-acceptance-related measures such as perceived benefits, barriers, efficacy, threat, social norms, and trust in government	Mandate: a new law mandating vaccination every 6 months ($N=229$) Negative monetary incentive: increased health taxes for those who do not get vaccinated every 6 months by 50% ($N=244$) Positive monetary incentive: decreased health taxes for those who get vaccinated every 6 months by 50% ($N=228$) Information about a study concluding the need for a booster shot every 6 months ($N=228$)	Not specified	Health policy	Vaccination intentions were related to perceived benefits, barriers, efficacy, and social norms. Compliance intentions were medium ($M=3.13$ on a 1–5 scale). Only 20.2% showed strong acceptance of periodic vaccination, lower than the pre-pandemic seasonal flu shot acceptance rate	4
Wang et al. 2023 Frontiers in Public Health $N=1000$ (working-age adults)	China	Vaccine acceptance	Gain-framed messages Loss-framed messages Physician consultation Cash incentives	Not specified	Health policy	The study found that loss-framing information and subsidized physician consultations significantly improved vaccine acceptance, while cash incentives did not. This effect was stronger among those with higher perceived infection risk and severity, and unvaccinated individuals with lower confidence in vaccine safety	3/4
Reynolds et al. 2020 International Journal of Environmental Research and Public Health $N=4391$ General public	United Kingdom and USA	Support for obesity prevention policies Beliefs about the causes of obesity (environmental, genetic, and willpower factors)	Exposing respondents to different messages about the causes of obesity, emphasizing either the environmental influence on obesity or human behavior in general	Not specified	Health policy	Intervention messages did not significantly increase support for obesity prevention policies. Messages highlighting the environment's role in obesity had mixed effects on beliefs—one increased the perception of environmental influence, while another reduced it. U.S. participants were more likely to attribute obesity to genetics, while U.K. participants emphasized willpower. Overall, policy support was higher in the U.K. than in the U.S.	3/4

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Appendix (Continued)

Authors/year/journal/ participants	Country	Dependent variable	Treatment	Control group	Policy domain	Key findings	Type
Ye et al. 2021 International Journal of Environmental Research and Public Health *N* = 298 (college students)	China	Intention to get the vaccine Health beliefs (perceived susceptibility, perceived severity, perceived benefits, and perceived costs)	Gain-framed messages Loss-framed messages Narrative messages Non-narrative messages	Not specified	Health policy	Loss-framed, narrative messages effectively motivated college students to get vaccinated by making the risks of inaction more personal and compelling, thereby shifting their health beliefs in favor of vaccination	3
Ylisalo et al. 2023 Political Research Exchange *N* = 1131 General public	Finland	Acceptability of mandatory vaccination Willingness to take a non-mandatory vaccine Preparedness to refuse a mandatory vaccine	Scenarios combining herd immunity thresholds (70% or 90%) and one of three justifications for mandatory vaccination (economy, health, or rights)	Not specified	Health policy	Health justifications were more effective at 90%, while rights-based justifications worked better at 70% There was no increase in refusal rates, indicating no strong negative reactions to the justifications Higher thresholds alone did not significantly boost acceptability of mandatory vaccination	4
Arriola et al. 2024 Comparative Political Studies *N* = 622 (Zambian politicians)	Zambia	Support for abortion liberalization	Information on the human cost of unsafe abortion	Not specified	Health policy	Wealthier women politicians were less likely to support abortion liberalization even when informed about the human cost of unsafe abortion compared to their fewer wealthy counterparts	2
Kishishita and Matsumoto 2024 European Journal of Political Economy *N* = 4367	Japan	Political support for increased healthcare insurance contributions	Information about self-benefits from the public healthcare system and, in some cases, fiscal risks	*N* = ~1456	Health policy	Informing about self-benefits increased support by 28.9% for those unaware of fiscal unsustainability. However, this effect was nullified when fiscal risks were also communicated	2
Heinzel and Liese 2021 West European Politics *N* = 4000	Germany	Support for COVID-19 public measures	Institution-endorsed recommendations from health ministries, public agencies, WHO and universities	*N* = ~800	Health policy	Institutional endorsements generally had little influence on average; polarization was observed, with expertise perception shaping responses	3
Heinisch and Werner 2024 Comparative European Politics *N* = 1200	Austria	Perception of being affected by the COVID-19 pandemic and support for policies to contain it	Survey questions on subjective affectedness in health and finances, and conjoint experiment on policy preferences	*N* = ~400	Health policy	Populist attitudes increase the perception of being affected by the pandemic, especially in health, and lead to opposition to policies that limit individual freedom	4
Naumann et al. 2024 Journal of European Social Policy *N* = 4493	Germany	Attitudes toward pension benefits for migrants and natives	Vignettes varying pensioners' ethnic background (Turkish vs. German), income, contribution years, and family structure	Not specified	Pension policy	Pensioners with a Turkish background received lower pension allocations from respondents compared to native Germans, even when income and contribution years were identical, indicating welfare chauvinism	4
Fernández et al. 2023 Journal of European Social Policy *N* = total 3000 (approx. 1000 per country)	Germany, Spain, USA	Preferences for pension policy reforms (retirement age, pension spending)	Split-sample survey experiment providing information on predicted future pension benefits (replacement rates)	Not specified	Pension policy	Providing information on future pension benefit declines increased support for raising retirement ages and reallocating funds from other social programs to pensions, particularly through learning and priming effects	2

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Appendix (Continued)

Authors/year/journal/participants	Country	Dependent variable	Treatment	Control group	Policy domain	Key findings	Type
Schuetz et al. 2023 European Journal of Political Economy $N = 1000$ General public	Germany	Perceived necessity for reforms Preferences for specific reform measures such as increasing the retirement age, decreasing the pension level, increasing contribution rates, or increasing tax subsidies	Computer-assisted telephone interviews Salience group (T1): information about the ratio of people of retirement age to working-age people in 1990 Information group (T2): information about the correct ratios for the years 2020 and 2050	$N = 333$ Received no prior information about demographic change	Pension Policy	Both salience and information treatments increased the perceived need for pension reforms, with salience boosting support by 15.2% of a standard deviation and information by 18.6%. The salience of demographic change made respondents more likely to favor raising the retirement age over lowering pensions, while information increased support for raising contributions over tax subsidies. East Germans responded differently from West Germans, with overestimating the old-age dependency ratio for 2020 reducing the impact of the information treatment, while overestimating the ratio for 2050 strengthened the salience effect. Additionally, male and older respondents were more likely to support raising the retirement age than female and younger respondents	2
Lawrence et al. 2013 Policy Studies Journal $N = 789$ General public	USA	Support for social policies, specifically targeting two policy areas: healthcare and urban aid	Presenting respondents with policies aimed at specific target groups, including positively regarded groups (e.g., elderly, children) and negatively regarded groups (e.g., government workers, low-income single mothers)	Not specified	Social policy	Public support for social policies is strongly influenced by the target group. Policies aimed at positively regarded groups, such as the elderly, tend to receive more support than those targeting less popular groups, like government workers. Healthcare policies generally enjoy higher support than urban aid, especially when no specific target group is identified. Conservatives and Republicans are more likely to oppose policies directed at unpopular groups, while liberals and Democrats are more inclined to support universal policies and are less influenced by the target group	4
Ford and Kootstra 2017 Journal of Ethnic and Migration Studies $N = 2117$ (main) $N = 3179$ (follow-up)	United Kingdom	Public support for welfare policies	Targeting welfare policies by ethnicity versus class/income	Not specified	Social policy	White British respondents showed strong support for class-targeted policies but much lower support for ethnically targeted policies	4
Kawata and Nakabayashi 2023 Journal of Policy Modeling $N = 15{,}000$ General public	Japan	Policy preferences	Policy packages consisting of five attributes: poverty relief, pensions, health insurance, infrastructure, and education	$N = 7500$ Did not receive information	Social policy	Providing information on the poverty rate in the first wave shifted respondents' preferences toward supporting poverty relief programs, either by increasing or reallocating the budget. These effects persisted in the second wave, 5 months later, across a broad range of respondent backgrounds and political views. However, by the third wave, 1 year later, the effects had diminished	2
Zhirkov et al. 2023 Journal of Experimental Political Science $N = 1271$	USA	Support for welfare policies	Deservingness and race stereotypes	Not specified	Social policy	Stereotypes about race significantly reduced support for welfare when measured with spending preferences rather than general attitudes	4

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Authors/year/journal/ participants	Country	Dependent variable	Treatment	Control group	Policy domain	Key findings	Type
Kawata et al. 2023 Political Psychology *N* = 15,000 General public	Japan	Policy preferences	Narrative information about the financial struggles of a single-parent household Statistical information about the prevalence of poverty among single-parent households	*N* = 5000 No additional information provided	Social policy	Narrative information significantly increased support for poverty relief and education spending compared to both statistical information and no information. While statistical evidence had a positive impact, it was less effective than narrative-based messaging. The narrative advantage was especially strong among individuals already aware of societal poverty levels. Notably, there were no significant differences in the effectiveness of the narrative approach based on partisanship, income, or education, suggesting its broad applicability across demographic groups	4
Zakharov 2024 European Journal of Political Economy *N* = 2016 (main) *N* = 1257 (follow-up)	Russia	Preferences for redistribution and social policy	Information provision through video explaining total taxes and social security contributions	Not specified (video with only income tax info)	Social policy	Information about total taxes, including hidden social security payments, reduced preferences for state spending, especially among those overestimating the taxes initially	2
Colombo and Ray 2024 Political Psychology *N* = 2690	Italy	Policy preferences (generosity of social benefits, universalism of social benefits and conditionality of social benefits)	Information about compliance with COVID-19 lockdown measures	*N* = 1345 Did not receive the information	Social policy	Trust influenced preferences for generous social benefits, but did not significantly affect support for universalism or conditionality. Positive information about community cooperation increased trust and boosted support for generous policies, while breached trust had the opposite effect, decreasing support. While accurate information helped update trust levels and shaped emotional responses, it did not impact institutional trust	2
Thorp and Larner 2024 Political Psychology *N* = 3393 (Wales) *N* = 1707 (Scotland)	United Kingdom	Perceived deservingness of welfare claimants	Manipulation of responsibility for impairment (birth, motorcycle accident, illicit drug use)	Not specified	Social policy	Claimants perceived as responsible for their impairment were viewed as significantly less deserving of welfare assistance, especially among those holding authoritarian values	4
Bremer and Bürgisser 2023 Political Science Research and Methods *N* = 3600	Germany, Italy, United Kingdom	Public support for welfare state recalibration in times of austerity	Split-sample and conjoint experiments focusing on trade-offs in social spending (pensions, education, childcare, labor market policies)	Not specified	Social policy	Citizens prioritized pension and education spending over labor market and family policies when confronted with austerity trade-offs	4
Chueri et al. 2024 West European Politics *N* = 2877 (Germany) *N* = 1393 (Switzerland) *N* = 1342 (Denmark) *N* = 1341 (Sweden)	Germany, Switzerland, Denmark, Sweden	Perception of welfare deservingness	Factorial vignette experiment (unemployment benefit claimants with varying characteristics)	Not specified	Social policy	Populist Radical Right Parties (PRRP) voters exhibited selective solidarity, showing less support for "least deserving" claimants but no greater support for "most deserving" claimants compared to mainstream voters	4

Note: Type: 1 = methodological; 2 = direct (information provision); 3 = indirect (priming, framing); 4 = factorial.

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